My very success with Campbell made it difficult, in a way, for me to take my writing career seriously. Might it not be that I was a one-editor writer? Perhaps I could only please Campbell and no one else. Worse yet, I always discussed my stories with Campbell, so there was a question in my mind as to how much of the success of my stories was mine and how much Campbell's.

The one story I had written in recent years that did not involve any discussions at all with Campbell had been "Grow Old with Me," and look at what had happened there.

What would happen to me, then, if something happened to Campbell? If he quit or were fired or died? Might it not be possible that I would then find suddenly that I was no writer at all?

Something like that almost happened on April 9, in fact. On that day I happened to call my mother to pass the time of day and was told that my father had heard on the radio that Street & Smith had suspended all its pulp magazines. For a short time, in my mind, Astounding was gone, Campbell was gone, and I wasn't a writer anymore.

Then I got the New York Times and found that Street & Smith had indeed suspended all its pulps, but that there had been one exception : Astounding would still continue to be published!

Still, the escape was a narrow one, and despite my recent sale of "—And Now You Don't" and the huge check it had brought in, I felt completely insecure as far as my writing career was concerned. There was no way I could see myself making a living at the typewriter in any way or under any circumstances—so I accepted the job at the Medical School.

And yet if Campbell represented a dead end to me, was there any way of branching out? If I couldn't follow Heinlein into the slicks, was there anyplace else I could forge a path for myself?

On March 21, 1949, I had attended a lecture given by Linus

Pauling. It was the best lecture I had ever heard. Even Gertrude, who was present, and who did not understand a word, enjoyed it. It was possible, then, to make science attractive to anyone.

Inspired by Pauling's speech, and remembering Jack Segal's remark months before about what a good explainer I was, I decided to write a piece of nonfiction. I called it "Detective Story for Non-chemists" (a title based on